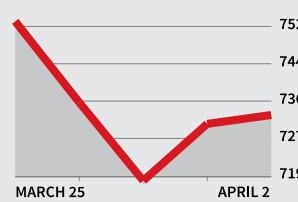


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 73319.55 (-263.67)



IN FOCUS

	Week's close	Week's change
Nifty 50	22713.10	-106.50
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.15	-0.07
US Dollar (in ₹)	93.10	-1.71
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	146021.00	+3651
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	227813.00	+6166



LOGISTICS.

India must focus on multimodal connectivity and digitisation of the maritime sector, says IAPH President Jens Meier **p8**

PULSE.

Wearable tech promises to keep fitness goals on track, but data privacy remains a worry **p9**

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MONDAY SPECIALS.

BRANDLINE

Inside Kerala's meme-fuelled poll battle



Kerala's election season now comes with two certainties: monsoon-like political thundershowers... and a full-blown digital downpour on social media. What we are witnessing is less a campaign and more a daily "war of wits", where the three political fronts trade punches in real time, armed not with microphones but memes. **p6**

QUANTUM

Why nuclear fusion is gaining funding

Nuclear fusion, arguably a yet-to-be-proven commercial energy source, is gaining traction. You have large research projects such as the International Thermonuclear Experimental Reactor (ITER), a multi-country endeavour located in France (to which, incidentally, India is contributing ₹745 crore in 2026-27), alongside many fusion start-ups, which have been receiving investor interest and aim to produce energy in the next decade. **p7**

Banks seek RBI relief as rising yields hit G-Secs

PORTFOLIO STRAIN. Propose to stagger mark-to-market losses over four quarters

K Ram Kumar
Mumbai

Banks have knocked on the Reserve Bank of India's door, seeking relaxation to spread the provisioning they will need to make for the losses incurred by their bond portfolio due to substantial hardening of yields in the fourth quarter (Q4) of FY26.

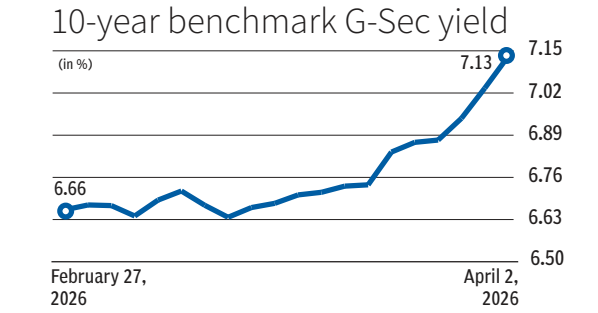
Their ask is that the provisioning for mark-to-market losses on investments should be allowed to be spread over four quarters, beginning Q4FY26. This will take the pressure off their bottomline.

WAR IMPACT

In the fourth quarter (January-March), Government securities' (G-Secs) yields spiked, especially from February-end, with the onset of the West Asia war.

For example, yield of the 10-year benchmark G-Sec (6.48 per cent GS 2035) jumped 45 basis points (bps) to close at 7.04 per cent on March 30, 2026 (last day of trading in Q4FY26) against the December-end 2025 closing level of 6.59 per cent.

The last time banks made a



similar request to the RBI was in 2018, and the regulator had allowed them to spread their losses (due to a sharp increase in G-Sec yields) by providing for depreciation on investments over four quarters, commencing from the quarter in which the loss was incurred.

Bond yields and prices are inversely co-related and move in opposite directions. So, with the yield of the aforementioned G-Sec rising 45 bps, its price crashed about ₹3 in the fourth quarter.

The war has triggered concerns in the bond market that rising global crude oil prices could have an inflationary effect on the economy. This, in turn, may require the RBI's rate setting panel (the Monetary Policy Committee) to

up the repo rate in either its June or August monetary policy review to curb inflationary pressures.

Bankers say it is not just banks that have taken a hit on their treasury portfolio, and the RBI, too, could face the heat of the spike in G-Sec yields. They pointed out that the central bank purchased G-Secs aggregating about ₹7 lakh crore from banks under open market operations (OMOs) to provide them durable liquidity in FY26.

"So, the central bank's portfolio of G-Secs purchased under the OMO window, too, will be subject to the impact of spike in yields. This could have implications for declaration of dividend to the government for FY26," said a banker.

The RBI transferred ₹2,68,590 crore as surplus to the Central government for FY25. The Union Budget for FY27 budgeted dividend/surplus of ₹3.16 lakh crore from the RBI, nationalised banks and financial institutions against ₹3,04,590 crore (revised) for FY25.

TREASURY LOSSES

Venkatakrishnan Srinivasan, Founder & Managing Partner, Rockfort Fincap LLP, said that while rising yields typically result in mark-to-market pressures on bond portfolios, banks — being natural participants in the bond market — may have largely managed this risk through active portfolio rebalancing and prudent treasury management.

"As a result, treasury losses are likely to have been contained to an extent. At the same time, with strong double-digit credit growth, improved net interest margins and significantly lower NPAs, the overall profitability of banks in the last fiscal year is expected to remain robust. This provides some cushion to the system, even as bond market volatility persists," he said.

War crisis: Global cloud majors look to India as data centre hub

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

India is set to benefit from the war in West Asia and may emerge as a regional hub for cloud infrastructure, as the crisis has triggered a surge in demand for data centre capacity in the country from global hyperscalers and Gulf-based clients.

Global cloud majors, including Google Cloud, Amazon Web Services and Microsoft Azure, are seeking larger co-location deals with Indian data centres, industry sources said.

As per one source, AWS is talking to five co-location providers like CtrlS, Sify, NTT, CapitaLand and even Airtel's Nxtra to build data centres to host public cloud regions. When *businessline* reached out to players like Nxtra, they declined to comment.

Demand for data centre capacity has spiked in the last three-four weeks, ranging between 200 and 500 MW, Sunil Gupta, Co-Founder, Managing Director and CEO of cloud infrastructure provider Yotta Data Services, told *businessline*.

Those from West Asia are in a particular rush to close the contract. These are huge inquiries even at a charge of \$60 per kilowatt, he said. "Since data centres cannot

EYEING SAFE HAVEN

- Google Cloud, Amazon Web Services and Microsoft Azure are seeking larger co-location deals with Indian data centres
- Demand for data centre capacity has spiked in the last three-four weeks, ranging between 200 and 500 MW



be opened and closed on an ad-hoc basis like offices, these contracts have long-term implications. In the midst of the global chaos, there is a golden opportunity for India to become a regional hub for data centres," said Gupta.

Overall, India stands to benefit from a structural reallocation of global cloud and data infrastructure demand, particularly as a secondary hub for the West Asia and Asia corridor, said Neha Singh, Co-Founder, Tracxn. "In the near term, hyperscalers are likely evaluating India as a contingency location for regional workloads, particularly as disruptions in Gulf-based infrastructure raise operational risks."

STRATEGIC LEVERAGE

Companies also have an option of migrating workloads to data centres in Europe or the US. Ultimately, where these workloads shift is a factor of cost and India has a clear advantage in pricing, as

per RackBank. "Building a 100 MW AI facility in India is roughly \$5-6 million compared to a place like Singapore and APAC, where it is around \$12-14 million. India gives double capacity at the same cost. For a hyperscaler, it's enough money to build an entirely second facility for free," said Narendra Sen, Founder & CEO, RackBank.

Apart from data centres, Indian cloud infrastructure providers have received huge requests for GPUs. Gupta said US-based GPU providers had contracted all of Yotta's GPU capacity, with contracts ranging from \$16 million for a year to \$1.3 billion for four years.

These orders from international players are for global requirements, and not India. While Gupta said that Yotta is commissioning an additional 30,000 B300/B200 GPUs over the next four months for India requirements, there has been noticeable concern regarding GPU shortage.

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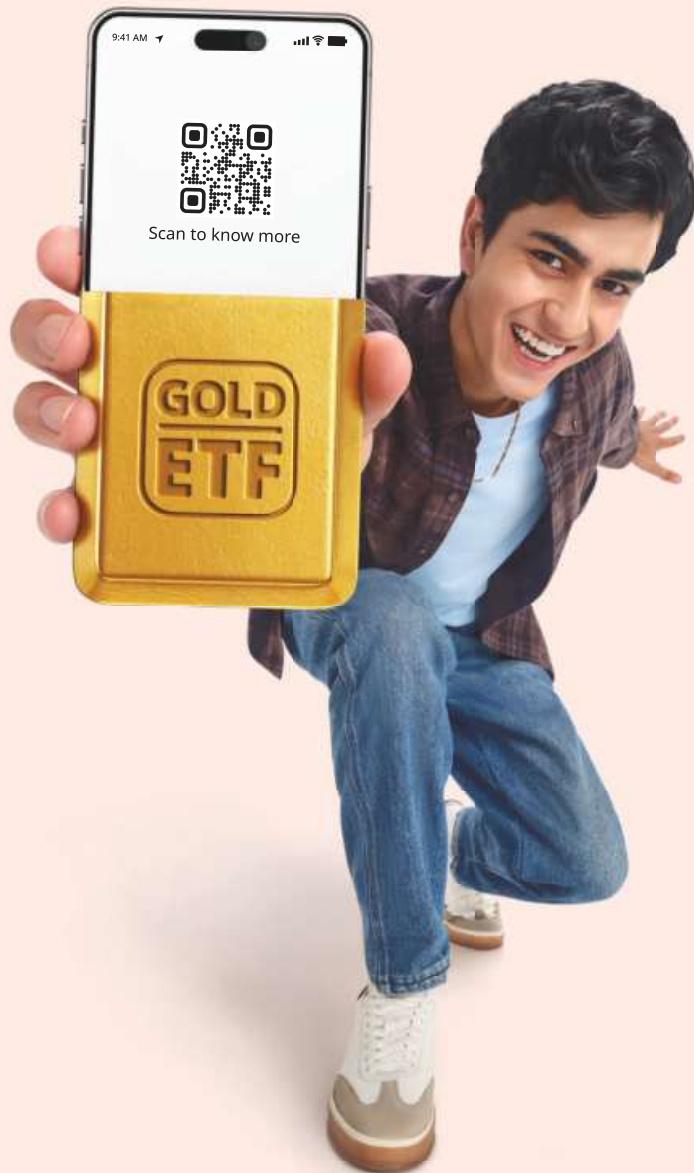
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QUICKLY.

SCR completes trials for installation of Kavach 4.0

Hyderabad:The South-Central Railway (SCR) has successfully completed field trials for a distance of 487 route km for the installation of Kavach 4.0, the indigenously developed automatic train protection system, surpassing the Railway Board's target of 402 route km. As part of the safety enhancement measures, steps were taken for the installation of Kavach 4.0 across the SCR network during the last financial year 2025-26. OUR BUREAU

Moody's cuts India's FY27 GDP outlook to 6%

New Delhi: Moody's Ratings has cut India's economic growth estimates for the current fiscal to 6 per cent from 6.8 per cent earlier, saying that the ongoing conflict in West Asia will moderate the growth momentum and raise inflation risks. In its credit opinion report on India, Moody's said that prolonged disruptions, particularly of LPG shipments due to the conflict, would lead to near-term household shortages, higher fuel and transport costs, and spillovers to food inflation through India's reliance on imported fertilizers. PTI

Our Bureau

Major government-administered ports in India handled 915 million tonnes of cargo in FY26, registering a 7.06 per cent growth over the previous year. The tonnage growth was the result of capacity expansion and efficiency gains, the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Water-

Buyback revival may lend support to shareholder confidence amid volatility

MARKET BOOST. Flexible open market route could aid price stability, give positive signal: Investment bankers

Akshata Gorde

The Securities and Exchange Board of India's (SEBI) proposal to revive open market buybacks through stock exchanges could lend steady support to shareholders during volatile phases, investment bankers said. It would also give companies a more flexible way to deploy surplus cash as well as support stock prices.

Unlike tender offers, which are executed within a short window of five days, open market buybacks allow companies to purchase shares gradually, creating sustained demand in the secondary market.

"In a volatile market, a buyback through the stock exchange route would send a strong positive signal, reinforce the management's confidence in the company's intrinsic value and enhance overall shareholder confidence while providing additional buying interest in the market," said Sourav Mallik, MD and Deputy CEO, Kotak Investment Bank.

INVESTOR PARITY

- Open market buybacks may support stocks during volatile phases
- Tax parity to boost investor participation
- It signals management confidence in valuations
- Also, it provides more flexibility for corporates compared to the tender route

Narinder Wadhwa, MD & CEO, SKI Capital Services, said, "Open market buybacks can help provide a steady demand cushion and improve price stability during volatile phases, though their impact is typically gradual compared to tender offers." This assumes significance at a time when the markets are seeing high volatility as the escalating war in West Asia has increased oil prices and growth concerns.

CAPITAL RETURNS The benchmark indices have lost more than 11 per cent each in March. Buybacks have remained a preferred capital return tool, particularly for cash-rich companies. In FY25-26, several companies, including Infosys with an ₹18,000 crore buy-

back, GHCL with around ₹300 crore, eClerx with ₹300 crore and Bajaj Consumer with around ₹186 crore, cumulatively deployed well over ₹20,000 crore towards buybacks. Between April 2018 and March 2023 also (prior to the curtailment in buyback size limits for the stock exchange route), around ₹43,000 crore across 86 buybacks were returned to shareholders through the stock exchange route. Bankers said the recent shift in taxation further strengthens the case for buybacks as capital gains for public shareholders are now taxed at a par with selling stock in the normal course, making it more tax efficient as compared to dividends. An investment banker, who did not wish to be



named, said the route could also change how companies manage market expectations. "This gives companies a way to support the stock without committing to an aggressive one-time price. It's more about creating a floor and showing confidence over time rather than a sharp re-rating," the person said, adding that it also allows firms to step in more actively during periods of market dislocation.

QUICK LAUNCH "It allows a quick launch of buyback, varies the buyback price over a longer period and provides flexibility to spread out the purchases over a longer period (based on price, cash flow or macro conditions)," said Mallik.

Major ports register 7 per cent cargo growth in FY26

Our Bureau

Mumbai

Major government-administered ports in India handled 915 million tonnes of cargo in FY26, registering a 7.06 per cent growth over the previous year. The tonnage growth was the result of capacity expansion and efficiency gains, the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Water-



Paradip port said that despite challenging market conditions like declining exports of iron ore, it saw 4.1 per cent

growth in volume and continued to lead among all ports on the Eastern Coast. The Jawaharlal Nehru Port Authority, India's largest container port, stood third as it handled 102.1 million tonnes. KEY PORTS Other key ports including Visakhapatnam, Mumbai, Chennai and New Mangalore also registered a strong per-

formance, contributing to the cargo throughput. "The record cargo handling of over 915 million tonnes by our major ports is a testament to the government's unwavering commitment to strengthening India's maritime sector," Union Minister of Ports, Shipping and Waterways Sarbananda Sonowal said. "The sustained growth in cargo handling has been

driven by capacity augmentation and modernisation of port infrastructure, strengthened multimodal connectivity and seamless hinterland linkages, adoption of digital and smart port initiatives, increased handling of key commodities including coal, crude oil, containers and fertilizers, as well as improved turnaround time and ease of doing business across ports," the Ministry said.

Why pepping up cereals with proteins is vital for Global South

KV Kurmanath

Hyderabad

While staples like rice, wheat and maize sustain millions in Asia and Africa, their refined grains lack essential nutrients, driving widespread protein malnutrition and diabetes. To revitalise traditional staples, scientists propose biofortifying cereals, as replacing just 5 per cent of refined carbohydrates with protein significantly reduces the risk of non-communicable diseases. A plant-based solution that combines cereals with protein-rich legumes could also reduce global greenhouse gas emissions by up to 32 per cent, since animal sources produce very high emissions. Though cereals themselves contribute to agricultural emissions through nitrogen fertilizer use and methane release in flooded rice systems, emissions by livestock-based meat are higher. "Rice feeds more than half of the world's population, yet it is naturally low in protein (6 per cent) and key essential amino acids that our bodies need for growth,

Quoting studies, he said that about 60 per cent of the calories humans consume in India come from refined carbohydrates

immunity and overall health. Improving the nutritional quality of rice, therefore, represents one of the most powerful ways to combat hidden hunger, particularly in Asia and Africa, where rice is a staple food," Nese Srinivasalu, a scientist with the International Rice Research Institute (IRRI), told *businessline*. "By increasing the protein and essential amino acid content of rice grains, we can help millions of people obtain better nutrition without changing their diets or food habits," he said. He, along with a few other scientists, published an article 'Cereal protein biofortification at the interface of nutrition, yield and sustainability' in *Nature Plants*. Quoting studies, he said that about 60 per cent of the calories humans consume in In-

dia come from refined carbohydrates. TYPE-2 DIABETES "Over 101 million people suffer from type-2 diabetes in India, who also face protein-energy malnutrition. Replacing carbohydrates with 5 per cent protein can reduce non-communicable diseases significantly," he said. Cereal-legume intercropping would be a strategy to meet essential amino acid needs in vulnerable populations. He said IRRI scientists developed high-protein, ultra-low glycemic index (low-GI) rice with elevated levels of essential amino acids, such as lysine. These nutritious varieties are high-yielding and the crop yield can be harvested within 100-110 days. These genetic mechanisms can be extended to other cereal crops. Through collaborations with the Max Planck Institute of Molecular Plant Physiology in Germany and the National Laboratory of Crop Genetic Improvement at Huazhong Agricultural University in China, researchers identified genes that control protein accumulation and essential amino acid composition in cereals.

Electric motorcycle makers eye 50,000 units by FY27 on Matter AI bike, Royal Enfield push

Amit Vijay Mohile

Mumbai

The electric motorcycle market in India remains small but is gearing up for a sharp scale-up, with manufacturers targeting volumes of 40,000-50,000 units by FY27. Electric motorcycle sales were 17,173 units in FY26, according to Vahan data, marking a 28 per cent year-on-year rise from 13,430 units. Despite this growth, the category remains minuscule — accounting for less than 0.1 per cent of the overall two-wheeler market and a fraction of the 13 lakh electric scooters sold during the year, highlighting the long runway ahead. The push is being led by a mix of start-ups and legacy players. Ahmedabad-based Matter Motor Works, which debuted with India's first geared electric motorcycle, is betting on AI-led differentiation to drive adoption, positioning intelligence, not just battery size, as the next growth lever. "If electric motorcycles have to go mainstream in India, they have to get smarter, not just cheaper. Improving real-world range and riding



experience through AI is what can expand the market, not just shift share," said Mohal Lalbbhai, Founder and Group CEO, Matter. The company plans to roll out its first AI-based update by mid-2026. MARKET SHIFT The competitive landscape is already shifting. Early mover Revolt Intellicorp saw volumes decline 10 per cent to 10,444 units, while newer players scaled rapidly. Oben Electric grew 298 per cent to 3,719 units and Ultraviolette Automotive rose 384 per cent to 2,102 units, reflecting churn in leadership within a still-nascent segment. Pricing is emerging as a key trigger. Ola Electric cut prices on its Roadster range, with entry variants now closer to 100 cc petrol motorcycles and higher-capacity models seeing reductions of up to ₹60,000, an early push towards unlocking mass-market demand.

EVOLVING DEMAND On the demand side, use cases are evolving. Electric motorcycles are increasingly being seen as better suited than scooters for higher-load and longer-distance applications such as delivery, logistics and bike-taxi operations, particularly in tier-2 and tier-3 markets where operating economics are more decisive. The next phase of growth will be shaped by new launches. Royal Enfield's electric entry, the Flying Flea, is set to reach dealerships this month, marking the first major push from a legacy player. TVS Motor is preparing an electric Apache for a late-2026 or early-2027 debut, while Hero MotoCorp and Bajaj Auto are expected to step up activity over the next 18-24 months. If scooters defined the first phase of India's EV transition, motorcycles could shape the next, but the shift is likely to be slower and more uneven across segments and use cases. "Electrification in India's two-wheeler market has so far been predominantly scooter-led, with motorcycles, despite forming the bulk of the market, still at a nascent stage," said Hemal Thakkar, Senior Director and Senior Practice Leader at Crisil. He added that motorcycle usage demands longer range, higher durability and versatility across urban and rural conditions, making electrification more complex from both a technology and cost standpoint. Current offerings remain split between premium performance models and more affordable options that still face limitations around range, charging infrastructure and service reach. "While upcoming launches, including Royal Enfield's Flying Flea and other OEM entries, signal rising strategic interest, meaningful scale-up will depend on delivering competitive pricing, real-world range and reliability together. We see electric motorcycles as a medium-to long-term opportunity, with the segment likely to remain ICE-dominated in the near term," Thakkar said.

Rasna's Jumpin bet drives pivot into ₹25,000 crore ready-to-drink market

Amit Vijay Mohile

Mumbai

Ahmedabad-based soft drink concentrate maker Rasna is pivoting beyond its core business with a ₹350 crore acquisition of Jumpin from Hershey India, marking its entry into the ₹20,000-₹25,000 crore ready-to-drink (RTD) market as it builds a three-engine growth strategy. The nearly 50-year-old brand, which commands about 70 per cent share in the soft drink concentrate segment, derives around 40 per cent of its revenue from exports. It is now targeting

double-digit growth in CY26 and aims to scale into a ₹1,800-₹2,000 crore business by FY27. The shift follows a weather-hit FY25, when unseasonal rain disrupted peak summer demand. Rasna is now betting on an early summer, expansion in quick commerce and a sharper push into RTD drive recovery. "RTD is a large market for us. Rasna and Jumpin are complementary engines of growth," Chairman Piruz Khambatta told *businessline* on the sidelines of the Confederation of Indian Industry's (CII) Western Re-

gion Annual conference on 'Driving Innovation, Growth and Global Competitiveness'. He added that the company is differentiating through lower sugar content — around 7 brix compared to 13-14 brix for competitors — and added vitamins. The relaunch of Jumpin marks Rasna's most aggressive move into the fast-growing RTD segment dominated by Frooti, Maaza and Slice. The company is targeting a 5-7 per cent share of market over the next two years. REGIONAL PLAY Currently available in 125 ml and 200 ml packs at ₹10,



Piruz Khambatta, Chairman, Rasna

Jumpin is positioned as a lower-sugar, fortified offering. The acquisition provides Rasna an immediate foothold in on-the-go consumption, compressing what would have been a longer organic build-out. Industry sources add that

Rasna is investing ₹45-₹50 crore in a litchi concentrate plant in Patna to strengthen its presence in North and East India. The facility is expected to reduce logistics costs and improve margins in key markets such as Bihar, Jharkhand and the North-East. "The biggest bottleneck today is transportation cost... Bringing production closer to markets helps reduce freight," Khambatta said. Industry estimates suggest a 200-250 basis point margin improvement over time. PILLARS OF GROWTH Rasna's strategy now rests on three pillars — RTD expan-

sion through Jumpin, export growth led by Africa and cost optimisation via regional manufacturing. The company is also stepping up digital investments, with 60-70 per cent of media spends directed online, while quick commerce is emerging as a key growth driver. The success of the strategy will depend on how quickly Jumpin scales in a highly competitive market while the core business sustains volumes. Despite the pivot, Rasna continues to rely on its concentrate portfolio, supported by a distribution network of over 1.3 million outlets, tar-

With 26.3 lakh units, SUVs continue to rule car market in FY26 with 56% share

Top 5 best selling vehicle segments in FY26

S. No.	Segment	FY26		FY25	
		Sales	%	Sales	%
1	SUV	26,34,666	55.8	23,66,274	54.3
2	Compact	9,88,469	20.9	10,20,311	23.4
3	MPV	5,31,563	11.3	4,68,139	10.8
4	Mid Size	3,98,691	8.4	3,41,092	7.8
5	Van	1,39,769	3.0	1,35,672	3.1

Source: Industry sources

S Ronendra Singh

New Delhi

Sports utility vehicles have become the best selling segment in the Indian market again in FY26 as more customers prefer them as compared to the other products on offer. Data sourced from industry sources indicated that more than 26.34 lakh SUVs were sold in FY26, and the share had gone up to around 56 per cent during the year in among passenger vehicles (PVs) in the country. In FY25, it was 54.3 per cent, with sales of around 23.66 lakh units. In terms of rankings, Tata Motors' Nexon SUV tops the chart with 2,16,054 units during FY26 against 1,63,089 units in FY25. Hyundai Motor's Creta followed at 2,01,921 units against 1,94,871 units in the year-ago period. According to the data, Tata's small SUV 'Punch' is ranked third with 1,83,980 units in FY26 against 1,96,572 units in FY25. Maruti Suzuki's Brezza is at number four with 1,80,104 units against 1,89,163 units in FY25.

HIGHEST SELLING "Nexon and Punch emerged as the highest selling SUV models in H2, underscoring the strength of our SUV portfolio... Our recent launches of Sierra, refreshed Punch and the petrol version of Harrier and Safari continue to see progressive

growth in customer traction, across bookings, enquiries and deliveries. Looking ahead, industry momentum is expected to sustain, led by growth in SUVs, CNG versions and EVs," Shailesh Chandra, MD & CEO, Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles, said. Mahindra & Mahindra's Scorpio ranks fifth in the list with sales of 1,78,800 units in FY26 against 1,64,842 units. Partho Banerjee, Senior Executive Officer, Marketing & Sales, Maruti Suzuki India, said that with options available like petrol, hybrid, CNG and electric (with e-Vitara), in the SUV segment, there are more choices for the customers in this segment.

STRONG HYBRID "Presently, we are having a strong hybrid in Grand Vitara, Victoris and Invicto, and we feel that we are giving options to the customer in the mid-SUV segment — they can go for internal combustion engine, CNG... Just to give a perspective, even the underbody CNG is doing very well. Victoris with underbody CNG, which is the first in the segment. Of the total bookings which we are receiving, the booking of CNG is almost 40 per cent," Banerjee told reporters recently. According to Puneet Gupta, Director at S&P Global Mobility, the continuous launch of new models across diverse price points and size segments has democratised SUV ownership in the country.

DHL Express eyes growth in sunrise sectors

Aishwarya Kumar

Bengaluru

International shipping giant DHL Express is intensifying its presence in India as part of its global 'Strategy 2030' roadmap, with a sharper focus on sunrise sectors and infrastructure expansion to drive growth over the next five years. RS Subramanian, SVP South Asia, said the company aimed to grow its global topline by 50 per cent compared to its 2023 base, with India emerging as a key market within a group of 20 priority countries identified for future growth. "India will be among the top markets in terms of opportunity and scale," he said. The company is prioritising sectors, such as life sciences, new energy, e-commerce and digital sales. In life sciences, DHL has strengthened its capabilities through GDP-certified temperature-controlled infrastructure and the acquisition of CRYOPDP, enhancing its ability to serve clinical trials and specialised pharma logistics. In the new energy space, the company sees significant untapped potential across the ecosystem, from installation to maintenance of renewable assets, such as solar and wind projects. E-commerce continues to remain a key driver, backed by investments in network capacity, automation and last-mile efficiency.

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QUICKLY.

Govt steps up LPG supply, urges calm amid conflict



New Delhi: Sale of small 5-kg LPG cylinders, available at LPG distributorships upon presenting valid ID proofs, has been stepped up, with about 6.6 lakh bottles sold since March 23 as the government ramps up supplies to meet demand. The 5 kg bottles are priced at market rates. PTI

CIL plans to offer 25.62 mt of coal via online auction

New Delhi: State-owned Coal India Ltd plans to offer 25.62 million tonnes of coal through online auction in the current month, a move expected to mitigate the impact of energy supply shocks on industries amid the West Asia crisis. The disruptions in LNG, LPG and crude oil supplies from West Asia have increased demand for coal, driving up its import prices. Coal India offered 32.532 mt of coal through e-auction in March against 20.5 mt in February this year. PTI

US snatches airman from Iran as Trump, Israel step up pressure

SMART PLAY. US diverted Iran’s attention, rescued officer from a mountain crevice

Reuters
Washington/Cairo

US special forces rescued a downed airman in Iran in a complex operation that averted a potential crisis for President Donald Trump, who issued renewed threats to intensify attacks if Tehran did not re-open the Strait of Hormuz.

Trump announced the rescue in the early hours of Sunday in a social media post that described the operation, in a mountainous area of Iran, as “one of the most daring Search and Rescue Operations in US History”.

The airman, the weapons officer of an F-15 jet shot down on Friday, was wounded but “will be just fine”, Trump said in a message on X posted by Press Secretary Karoline Leavitt. The pilot of the aircraft was rescued on Friday.

In another post, laden with expletives, Trump repeated a demand that Iran open the Strait of Hormuz, which has been largely shut since the start of the war five weeks ago.



TENSIONS GALORE. An image purportedly of US aircraft destroyed during the mission to find a stranded airman in Iran, the Revolutionary Guards said, according to Iranian media REUTERS

“Tuesday will be Power Plant Day, and Bridge Day, all wrapped up in one, in Iran,” he said on his Truth Social platform.

WHO SAID WHAT

A senior Israeli defence official said Israel, which attacked a major petrochemicals facility on Saturday, was preparing to attack Iranian energy facilities within the next week, and was awaiting approval from Washington.

However, in an interview with Fox News on Sunday, Trump said Iran was negotiating and he believed a deal could be concluded by Monday.

With the impact from the

closure of the Strait on the global economy deepening by the day, the rescue of the US airman removed the risk for Trump of a hostage crisis.

A US official said the operation, in which Israel said it had assisted, involved dozens of military aircraft and encountered fierce resistance from Iranian forces.

Iran’s military said several US aircraft were destroyed during the operation, including two military transport planes and two Black Hawk helicopters.

Footage posted on social media showed burned-out aircraft wreckage, which Reuters verified was in the area.

The loss of the F-15 last

week as well as an A-10 ground-attack aircraft that came down in a separate incident, underlined the risks still facing US and Israeli air crew despite Trump’s assertions that Iran’s air defences had been largely destroyed.

A US official told Reuters that US forces had to destroy at least one of the aircraft used in the rescue mission because it malfunctioned but many details of what occurred in the operation remain unclear.

The Wall Street Journal reported that two MC-130Js aircraft used to carry out covert infiltrations were blown up by US forces after malfunctioning.

A senior administration official in Washington said the rescue involved a CIA deception campaign spreading word inside Iran that the US forces had already found the missing airman and were moving him on the ground for exfiltration out of the country.

Amidst the confusion, the missing weapons officer was located inside a mountain crevice and rescued, the official said in a statement.

NPCIL may come out with IPO soon

On the cards for 15 years			
	2023-24	2024-25	2025-26 (till January 2026)
Revenue	18,484	19,880	16,348
PBT	6,486	4,343	6,818
Dividend to govt	1,931	1,391	(to be declared)

Source: Report of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Science & Technology, Environment, Forests and Climate Change

M Ramesh
Chennai

The initial public offer of the public sector Nuclear Power Corporation of India Ltd (NPCIL), which has been in the offing for over 15 years, is expected to happen this year.

The Department of Atomic Energy told a Parliamentary committee recently that Budget 2026-27 had slashed equity support to NPCIL to ₹100 crore from ₹3,042 crore last year, because the company intends to come out with an IPO.

The Budget cut capital allocation to the Department from ₹11,977 crore to ₹9,966 crore.

The Department told a Parliamentary Standing Committee that went into the demands for grants for atomic energy that the “apparent decrease” was mainly because of the reduction in

equity support to NPCIL. NPCIL, which is the only company that runs nuclear power plants in India, operates 24 plants with a total capacity of 8,780 MW (excluding the 100 MW RAP-1 which is under long-term maintenance).

MORE POWER

NPCIL’s electricity generation increased to 56,881 million units (mu) in 2024-25 from 47,971 mu in the previous year, whose effect is reflected in terms of higher revenue. Yet, its profit before tax decreased by a third.

Notably, while revenue from operations in 2024-25 was ₹19,880 crore, the ‘cost of production’ was ₹10,904 crore — an operating surplus of ₹8,976 crore.

Yet, the pre-tax profit was only ₹4,343 crore; the rest of the surplus was absorbed by financing costs, depreciation and other non-operating expenses.

OPEC+ agrees on symbolic oil quota hike

Bloomberg

OPEC+ members agreed to raise their oil production quotas for May, a symbolic move as the West Asia conflict constrains output and shipments from several of the alliance’s largest members.

Key producers, led by Saudi Arabia and Russia, agreed to increase targets by about 2,06,000 barrels a day on Sunday, according to delegates who asked not to be identified.

With oil flows from the Persian Gulf throttled by the Iran war and top producers like Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Iraq and Kuwait forced to curtail supplies, such a move by the group is theoretical. Still, it may symbolise their intention to revive output as soon as hostilities ease.

Oil prices have been roiled by five weeks of conflict, climbing to almost \$120 a barrel last month, and soaring costs for products, such as jet fuel and diesel, are threatening a renewed wave of inflation. Brent futures settled near \$109 on Friday after US President Donald Trump vowed an escalation, which could prolong disruptions to energy flows through the Strait of Hormuz.

GST Council meeting likely in May-end or June

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi



WHAT RULES SAY. The body is mandated to meet at least once every quarter of the financial year ISTOCKPHOTO

With elections to be held soon in four States and a Union Territory, the wait for the new GST Council meeting is likely to take longer. The 57th meeting is expected to take place only in May-end or June.

The last Council meeting took place on September 3, 2025. According to the Rules for Procedure and Conduct of Business Regulations of the GST Council, the body is mandated to meet at least once every quarter of the financial year.

The rules also stipulate that a notice for the meeting must be dispatched at least seven days prior to the scheduled date, though an emergency meeting can be convened with two days’ notice. Typically, however, a 21-day notice period is observed.

Counting of votes in Tamil Nadu, West Bengal, Assam, Kerala and the Union Territory of Puducherry will take place on May 4.

Since it will take some time for the winning coalition or party to form the government, officials said that a

meeting of the council can take place only when the governments are in place in the poll-bound States.

AGENDA WORK ON

A meeting of the Council requires the presence of at least half (50 per cent) of the total members.

Officials said these four States and one UT constitute less than 20 per cent of the total strength (32), yet “going by the federal structure of the Council, every member is given equal importance”.

Meanwhile, work on the agenda is on. According to a senior official, the Council is likely to further ease the process of registration, refund and audit in its next meeting. According to the GST

portal, the total number of GST identification numbers was over 1.56 crore on October 31, 2025, which rose to over 1.63 crore on March 31, 2026, showing an increase of over 7 lakh.

After the Council’s recommendations, a simplified GST registration scheme for small and low-risk businesses was made effective from November 1, 2025.

With the introduction of an optional simplified scheme, registration is being granted on an automated basis within three working days from the date of submission of application in the case of low-risk applicants.

At the time of introduction, it was said that the new scheme would benefit around 96 per cent of new

Elections are nearing in Tamil Nadu, West Bengal, Assam, Kerala and Puducherry (UT). Counting of votes will take place on May 4

applicants applying for GST registration.

“Our officers have held multiple rounds of extensive meetings, and some work on the agenda is done. Once we get more concrete suggestions, we will finalise the agenda for the Council,” he said. The last Council meeting recommended a revamp of the rate structure.

According to tax experts, the artificial distinction between goods and services for the purpose of refund had led to significant working capital blockages for various industries.

The GST Council should consider allowing refunds of such accumulated ITC on input services, thereby ensuring seamless flow of credit and improved liquidity for businesses, they said.

Amid war crisis, CII proposes 20-point policy action to support MSMEs, investors

Our Bureau
New Delhi



Chandrajit Banerjee, Director General, CII

Industry chamber Confederation of Indian Industry (CII) on Sunday proposed a 20-point policy agenda for the government and the Reserve Bank of India to mitigate the risk on account of the war in West Asia.

The industry body suggested the setting up of a time-bound conflict-linked emergency credit line guarantee scheme, similar in spirit to the emergency credit line guarantee scheme implemented during the pandemic. This will help in additional collateral-free working capital to be extended to affected enterprises through government-backed guarantees, particularly targeting MSMEs, exporters and gas-dependent sectors.

MORATORIUM FOR MSME

At the same time, it proposed to the RBI to consider a temporary and clearly defined three-month moratorium and restructuring window for MSMEs, especially exporters and ancillary units

linked to export supply chains. “This may include calibrated flexibility in asset classification norms, with a defined deferment before special mention account and non-performing asset recognition is triggered, limited to sectors where disruption is demonstrable,” it said.

Also, the RBI could institute a special refinance window for MSMEs and other affected sectors, complemented by targeted liquidity support through instruments, such as targeted long-term repo operations, thereby enabling banks and non-banking financial companies to continue extending credit at reasonable cost to productive sectors.

Another action point is for banks to reassess and enhance working capital limits in deserving cases, particularly for export-oriented and gas-dependent units facing temporary stress. “A calibrated increase in cash credit limits of up to 20 per cent, coupled with concessional lending terms during the disruption period, would provide meaningful operational relief,” it said, adding that a temporary reduction or waiver of administrative banking charges for MSMEs and affected sectors could add to the benefit.

In order to sustain foreign capital inflows into primary markets during a period of heightened global uncertainty, the CII called for consideration of a temporary exemption from long-term capital gains tax for foreign investors in primary market investments, with the qualifying holding period extended from 2-3 years.

Further, the government and the RBI could institutionalise a standing economic shock response framework with pre-agreed, scenario-based policy play-

books calibrated to defined trigger points, such as including oil price thresholds at \$100, \$150 and \$200 per barrel, that bring together fiscal, monetary, trade and regulatory levers with clear coordination protocols across ministries and regulators.

FOREX SWAP WINDOW

There was also a suggestion for a special forex swap window for oil and gas public sector undertakings, enabling them to meet their dollar requirements in a manner that reduces volatility in the foreign exchange market and limits undue pressure on reserves.

Commenting on the evolving situation, Chandrajit Banerjee, Director General, CII, emphasised that India’s experience during previous crises had shown that coordinated fiscal and monetary action could significantly strengthen resilience. “The next phase of policy response may, therefore, need to focus on targeted liquidity support, credit facilitation, trade cost management and foreign exchange stability.”

Parliament body unhappy as PFBR power project cost rises to ₹8,181 crore

Ramesh M
Chennai



A file photo of a section of the prototype fast breeder reactor

A parliamentary panel has expressed concern over the delays in — and mounting cost of — executing the 500 MW prototype fast breeder reactor (PFBR) nuclear power project, whose construction began in 2004.

The project cost is now estimated at ₹8,181 crore as compared to the original ₹3,492 crore.

The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Science and Technology, Environment, Forests and Climate Change noted that the project “remains in the commissioning stage without having commenced power production and that no operating revenue, profit or dividend has been generated by BHAVINI (the government company set up for the project).”

PROJECT SIGNIFICANCE

The PFBR project is of critical national importance as it would set a template for India’s ambition to set up more fast breeder reactors. Fast breeder reactors use as fuel plutonium-239 that comes out as waste in the conventional uranium-235 reactors

and generate more plutonium-239, which is why they are called breeders. More importantly, they pave the way for using thorium as nuclear fuel; India has plenty of thorium. As fast breeder reactors generate energy, they can also convert thorium into uranium-233, which is nuclear fuel.

Thus, the PFBR is the first step in India getting into the second of the planned three-stage programme — the three phases can be broadly understood as relating to the use of uranium, plutonium and thorium as nuclear fuel. Yet, the project, which was originally slated to be completed by 2011, has already been delayed by 15 years.

Outstanding bank loans against shares hit a nine-month high

Rohan Das
Chennai

Even as the markets have remained volatile for much of FY26, the loans against shares and bonds have touched a nine-month high.

According to RBI data, outstanding gross bank credit against shares and bonds stood at ₹10,264 crore as of January 2026, up 5.1 per cent from the ₹9,766 crore at the same time last year. It was at ₹7,677 crore in January 2023 and ₹7,340 crore in January 2024.

Loans against shares are secured loans where borrowers pledge listed equities or bonds as collateral. Banks and NBFCs offer these at defined loan-to-value (LTV) ratios with interest rates linked to tenure and risk.

The figure, after steady increases through the last few months, is now at a nine-month high in January 2026.

BORROWING PATTERNS

However, banks hold a small fraction of the total credit against shares as NBFCs have a larger play in this segment.

For instance, Bajaj Finance’s total loan against securities AUM as of December 2025 stood at ₹3,562 crore,

Monthly credit	
Month	Amount (in ₹ crore)
Apr-25	10,488
May-25	9,412
Jun-25	9,886
Jul-25	9,730
Aug-25	9,807
Sep-25	9,835
Oct-25	10,066
Nov-25	9,752
Dec-25	10,150
Jan-26	10,264

Source - RBI

up 26 per cent from the year-ago period.

Vivek Iyer, Partner and Financial Services Risk Leader, Grant Thornton Bharat, said that during shorter market conditions borrowers use existing portfolios to fuel immediate-term liquidity, leading to increased lending against shares.

“When markets are weak, investors are typically unwilling to liquidate their holdings at lower valuations. They tend to want to hold on to the securities for a longer time in the hope that the market will recover,” he said.

In such a scenario, loans against shares provide an interim source of liquidity, allowing individuals to raise

funds while continuing to stay invested in the market, he added.

Iyer said, “Given the uncertain economic scenario, borrowers will hold on to the loans in the hope that interest rates will be reduced, bringing down their overall credit burden,” he said.

GENERATION GAP

Iyer further noted that the younger demographic tends to have a lower base of physical collateral such as property but a higher exposure to equities, and hence securities are becoming an alternative collateral option to borrow.

Certain policy tailwinds might also have spurred loan activity. In October 2025, the central bank removed the regulatory ceiling on such loans from ₹20 lakh to ₹1 crore. LTV for loans against shares was also proposed to increase to 60 per cent from the previous 50 per cent.

RBI data show other personal loans have also seen growth in the last 12 months. Loans against fixed deposits went up 13 per cent year-on-year at ₹1,54,360 crore, while loans against gold jewellery went up 1.2x times to ₹4,00,517 crore. Overall, personal loans went up by 15 per cent to ₹67,23,042 crore.

TODAY’S PICK.

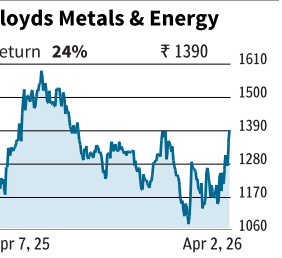
Lloyds Metals & Energy (₹1,390.05): BUY

Gurumurthy K
bl. research bureau

The short-term outlook is bullish for Lloyds Metals & Energy. The stock has been moving up very well over the last three weeks. The strong 8.7 per cent surge last week indicates that the upmove is gaining momentum. This has taken the share price well above a key resistance level of ₹1,320.

The region between ₹1,320 and ₹1,290 will now be a strong support zone. Lloyds Metals & Energy’s share price could rise to ₹1,550 from here. Traders can buy Lloyds Metals & Energy shares now at ₹1,390.

Accumulate on dips at ₹1,330. Keep the stop-loss at ₹1,260



initially. Trail the stop-loss up to ₹1,420 as soon as the stock goes up to ₹1,455. Revise the stop-loss higher to ₹1,460 and ₹1,495 when the price touches ₹1,486 and ₹1,510, respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹1,540.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

1
KERALA BANK

KERALA STATE CO-OPERATIVE BANK LTD
Head Office, Co-bank Towers, Palayam, Thiruvananthapuram - 695033

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04-04-2026

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The bid documents may be downloaded and submit bids through the portal <https://www.etenders.kerala.gov.in> of the Govt of Kerala.

Description	Details
e-Tender ID	2026_KSCB_848194_1
Date of issue	31-03-2026
Pre-bid meeting (online link will be shared through e-Tender)	13-Apr-2026 11:00 PM
Last date of submission of Bids	05-May-2026 04:00 PM
Date and time of Opening of Technical bid	07-May-2026 11:00 AM
Tender document, Fee, EMD	Please visit https://www.etenders.kerala.gov.in

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ON THE CAMPAIGN TRAIL.

The KitKat heist broke the Internet — a real-world robbery spawned a marketing and meme fest with every other brand joining it. But the Nestle chocolate brand stole all the honours.

Taking a sweet break

It all began when Nestle reported the theft of 12 tonnes of KitKat bars in transit from a factory in Italy to Poland. Nestle humorously turned the crisis into a marketing moment when it said that thieves took KitKat's tagline (have a break) too literally by making a break with their chocolate. From Domino's to KFC and Microsoft, everyone joined the KitKat heist party with condolence messages and spoofy takes. Kerala Tourism playfully said that it had checked its backwaters and found no chocolate there. While it was all in fun, everyone joining in unwittingly helped KitKat build more brand equity.

Rebellious by nature

British ethical beauty brand The Body Shop celebrates its 50th anniversary with the launch of a new campaign film, *Rebellious by Nature*, featuring actors Mandira Bedi, Sumedh Vasudev Mudgalkar and Diksha Singh, each a rebel in their own right, on screen and off it. Rooted in the brand's long-standing activist DNA, the campaign speaks out against unsolicited opinions and outdated rules even as it spotlights three of the brand's most loved products in India — the Edelweiss Serum, British Rose Body Butter and Ginger shampoo.

Biting into Bihu

Increasingly, national brands are going regional in their storytelling. Parle-G has just launched a two-part Bihu campaign that began with an unconventional two-and-a-half-minute music video. Featuring Assamese actor Partha Hazarika, with music by Nilotpal Bora and vocals by Dikshu, the film captured the infectious energy of Bihu. Building on the huge response it got for the music video, the biscuit brand has unveiled the main film — a poignant story of a musician named Ahir rediscovering his creative spirit as he stumbles into a vibrant Bihu celebration.

All charged up

Hero MotoCorp's Vida charges up the excitement of cricket with a purpose-led initiative. Every six hit by the Kolkata Knight Riders (KKR) will power something strong, says the brand. Vida, the title partner of KKR, has promised to install a 6kW fast charger for every six hit by KKR throughout the 2026 T20 season. As part of the campaign, Vida has also unveiled co-branded fast chargers in the signature KKR colours at prominent locations. An iconic installation was recently unveiled by KKR players, symbolising the partnership between sport, sustainability and the future of mobility.

NUGGETS.

Authenticity and influence

The fissures in influencer marketing came to the fore last week as India's netizens became polarised over a content creator from West Bengal. Everyone adored Pujarini Pradhan, a saree-clad village woman who unexpectedly posts about feminism, books and films from a rural home; her handle @lifeofpujaa ratcheted up 6,75,000 followers. But when she landed deals from Netflix and Audible, there was an uproar. Suddenly, there were accusations over whether Puja's personality was authentic or “constructed” — were the mud walls a set, or real? Meanwhile, many spoke out in support of Puja, too, slamming the detractors over a class and language bias. What the whole controversy shows is the growing distrust in the influencer ecosystem, and the jealousy and rivalry among content creators.

Is loyalty slipping?

Accenture's new research report, ‘Luxe eternal: The customer edit’, finds that in the luxury segment customer loyalty is weakening, and the conventional standards of luxury no longer carry the same weight. The report says that the active luxury customer base has experienced a notable contraction. After reaching approximately 400 million active buyers in 2022, the number has declined to roughly 340 million by 2025 globally — signalling a disconnect between rising global wealth and consumer interest in the luxury market. In India, loyalty is eroding, finds the report, with 73 per cent of luxury customers switching from their preferred brand in the past five years and 66 per cent saying that luxury had become more profit-driven than aspirational.

● BOTS AND BALLOTS

Inside Kerala’s meme-fuelled poll battle

E-ARENA. Social media and AI are the tools of choice as political parties slug it out ahead of the Assembly elections in God’s Own Country

Vinson Kurian

Kerala’s election season now comes with two certainties — monsoon-like political thunder-showers... and a full-blown digital downpour on social media. What we are witnessing is less a campaign and more a daily “war of wits”, where the three political fronts trade punches in real time, armed not with microphones but memes.

SWIFT MESSAGING

Each day’s political headlines are swiftly converted into tit-for-tat messaging. When allegations surfaced about the Left Front’s supposed understanding with the NDA, the CPI(M) fired back with a neat one-liner: “We have a deal only with the people.” Cue a crisply packaged explainer reel on the LDF government’s decade-long report card. Not to be outdone, BJP handles pushed viral content suggesting the CPI(M) and the Congress were “two sides of the same coin”.

CM IN DIGITAL SOUP

And then there was Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan snapping at someone who tried to raise a question midway through his campaign speech: “Go home and ask your folks.” The Congress cyber team didn’t let that pass. Within hours, it shot back: “Better sit at home and pontificate.” In Kerala’s digital battlefield, wit travels faster than wi-fi. Behind such rapid-fire exchanges are highly organised digital war-rooms as the new nerve centres of political strategy. Leading the charge in sheer scale is the BJP-led NDA. With an army of nearly 10,000 digital foot soldiers operating across roughly 50,000 Whats-



VOTE FOR HUMOUR. Political rivals in Kerala take virtual potshots at each other in the heat and dust of canvassing

App groups, the NDA’s online presence is relentless. A dedicated team functions out of the State election committee office for Rajeev Chandrasekhar, BJP State President and candidate from Nemom, and an additional war room in Thrikkakara. At the core is a 100-member State-level team led by Anoop Antony, General Secretary, which dissects, debates and despatches content sourced from multiple agencies. Social media influencers are very much a part of this strategy. One of the most creative digital videos put out by the right wing

party on social media shows a man washing a red cloth, which slowly fades and becomes saffron hued. LEFT NOT LEFT BEHIND The CPI(M)-led LDF is no laggard either. Its social media machinery has been in motion well ahead of the election buzz, through a steady stream of polished ads and curated interviews highlighting government achievements. The effort is steered by a seasoned media professional with a clear left-of-centre orientation, hosting panel-style discussions with senior party leaders. The Left is also promoting brand



ory of alleged “dark age” stories from the previous UDF regime, stands as a reminder that, in politics, even archives can be weaponised (when they’re not buffering). CONGRESS PLAYBOOK The Congress-led UDF operates with a slightly different playbook. It has two parallel streams — a quick-response team for instant rebuttals and an AI-driven unit focusing on video content and fact-checking. These outputs are funnelled through the social media pages of party leaders and affiliated organisations. Headed by Ernakulam MP Hibi Eden, the team also works to simplify and broadcast policy promises, including the guarantees articulated by Rahul Gandhi, especially for voters who may have missed the fine print but won’t miss a good reel.

MERCHANDISE MESSAGING

A popular new medium for messaging that has emerged in Kerala is apparel. Across the State you can see parties, mid-canvassing, distributing *mundu* and shirts with party symbols like the hand, hammer-and-sickle with star, and lotus.

COUNT ON KERALA

Even as the political parties slug it out, the State Election Commission, Kerala, has joined the social media blitz. Through agencies Bridging Dots and Stark Communications, it has flooded the internet with engaging campaigns urging citizens to be sure to ink their preferences. From Vote Chat (a chatbot) to Vote Knock (door-to-door campaigns) and Vote Vandī (mobile campaigns), the election body has shown as much, if not more, creativity as the political parties.

(With inputs from Chitra Narayanan)

Lego aces, brick by brick, in the age of Nvidia

THE CURIOUS MARKETER HARISH BHAT

Each year, I look forward to the report on the world’s most valuable and strongest brands, published by Brand Finance, a respected brand valuation consultancy firm. Here are some of the top conclusions of the 2026 report:

APPLE, TATA AND NVIDIA Apple remains the world’s most valuable brand, while Tata retains its top spot in India. Both these iconic brands have strengthened their valuations this year, through a consistent focus on their core purpose and by enhancing the trust and love they have earned among millions of customers. Nvidia’s brand value has more

than doubled since last year, and it is now the fifth most valued globally. This is an amazing rise in a single year, making it more valuable than Facebook and Walmart. Clearly, Nvidia’s rise signals the age of artificial intelligence, which is now upon us. Of the top eight — Apple, Microsoft, Google, Amazon, Nvidia, Tik Tok, Walmart and Samsung — seven are native technology brands, with Walmart being the sole exception. The report also lists the world’s “strongest” brands, which is quite different from the “most valuable” brands. These brands enjoy the strongest brand perception, which leads to the best outcome on customer behaviour. The five strongest brands are YouTube, WeChat, Microsoft, Google and Lego. While many of these headlines are not surprising, I would like to dwell on some of the traditional brands — such as Lego, Walmart, Deloitte and Michelin — that truly



surprised me with their resilience and strength in a world dominated by the rise and rise of AI. PLAYING WITH LEGO Lego is more than 90 years old, yet this toy maker holds its own as the fifth strongest brand in the world. It draws high admiration and enjoys a huge reputation. How does a toy brand manage this? First, it appeals both to children and adults, through toy sets of different complexities. As the Brand Finance re-

port points out, familiarity of toy brands generally falls among older groups. Defying this trend, Lego has a familiarity of 86 per cent even among 55- to 64-year-olds. To bolster this inter-generational appeal, Lego has developed strategic partnerships with popular brands such as Ferrari and Harry Potter. It has also built deep emotional links with its customers, based on the timeless human desires of creativity, imagination and joy. Here is a case-study in marvellous brand reinvention, particularly given that Lego was virtually bankrupt just about 20 years ago. SHOPPING AT WALMART Walmart is not as old as Lego, but still grey-haired at 64. Until around 15 years ago, it was slotted in our minds as a “traditional retailer” in a world overtaken by e-commerce. However, Walmart has evolved to become even more robust during the past few years. It began life with a hugely appealing consumer value

proposition of “everyday low prices”, backed by a strong supply chain and economies of scale. In the past decade, it also added “convenience” through its successful e-commerce business, powered by a treasure trove of data and thousands of its own stores as fulfilment centres. Its market capitalisation recently touched an astronomical \$1 trillion. RESILIENCE OF BRANDS Marketers may wish to study what has contributed to the continuing strength of traditional brands. A big takeaway for me from the Brand Finance report is that, while native digital and AI brands currently enjoy a tailwind, the stars of our brand universe include many traditional names that have built and evolved sharp and compelling customer value propositions. In the final analysis, this is what matters the most.

Harish Bhat is an avid marketer and bestselling author

● CONTENT CREATION

Hansa’s second act for a scroll-first audience

Next generation from the RK Swamy Hansa group launch a story-first, IP-driven venture tailored for the digital age

Rohan Das

From iconic five-day soaps and super-hit films to sports broadcasts and star-studded concerts, Hansa Vision, the production company from the RK Swamy Group, made a mark on Indian television for decades. Now, as the media industry resets for a new era of content consumers, the storied company from Chennai is revamping itself as Hansa Entertainment — and this time a new generation of leaders are stepping in at the helm. Hansa Entertainment will be led by Sruti Swamy and Siddharth Swamy — the grandchildren of the group’s founder RK Swamy — as Directors, while industry veteran Sujatha Narayanan will be CEO. The ensemble brings with it a broad mix of expertise. Narayanan has over 20 years of experience in film and content production, while Siddharth and Sruti have led the group’s technology-driven marketing consulting and real estate divisions, respectively. The trio’s objective is clear — build Hansa into a younger, faster and more focused brand that does not limit itself to movies or television shows but also creates content tailored for the digital age. As Siddharth puts it, content



PORTRAIT MODE. Sruti Swamy, Director, Hansa Entertainment

today goes beyond larger-than-life immersive movies to include OTT shows for planned, uninterrupted watch time, vertical ‘snackable content’ — portrait format suited for mobile phones — for short pockets between tasks, and podcasts for passive consumption in the background. He says Hansa will double down on each of these new-age formats and, unlike incumbent production houses that take a ‘one-size-fits-all’ approach, it will curate offerings based on the format. Vertical content is a special focus area, as it is the fastest-growing segment in the industry. “In China, the vertical format has already overtaken the domestic box office. The Indian market is projected to be around \$4.5 billion



Siddharth Swamy, Director, Hansa Entertainment

in the next five years,” he says. Moreover, with tier-2/3 cities accounting for about 70 per cent of consumption in this format, the plan is to be regional-first across multiple languages. IP CREATION Hansa’s legacy of content creation could prove an advantage — it can leverage the infrastructure and contacts built over decades of production across regions. Narayanan points to the natural synergy between Hansa’s past and what it is setting out to do now. “Production houses come with a legacy and people are already responding positively to us when we go out into the market seeking talent, stories or brands to collaborate with. There is an instant trust,



Sujatha Narayanan, CEO, Hansa Studio

and we believe our production values and storytelling will stand out from the clutter,” she says. That said, the firm will deviate from legacy in terms of its business model — Hansa Entertainment will prioritise owning and distributing IP rather than being a service provider to platforms. Sruti believes the market is open to this shift, and Hansa is building a team with expertise in creating and distributing IP. “At the end of the day, you are working with people and the key thing is to have the right team to get through it,” she says. The company has brought in filmmaker and writer Barath Neelakandan as content lead and Aditi Ravindranath as films and OTT business lead. Amid the rising use of AI across

industries, Siddharth says Hansa plans to deploy AI mainly for operational efficiency, including lowering production costs and understanding platform dynamics. “We are also exploring newer layers, such as interactive chatbots and early-stage AR/VR integrations, to build tech-enabled content ecosystems,” he says. Creative decisions like scripting and ideation will remain human-led, he added. Looking ahead, Narayanan says the company has initiated plans for a couple of projects and would see a positive movement soon. As for the production roadmap, she says the firm has specific monthly, quarterly and yearly targets for each vertical, without revealing the exact details. Srinivasan Swamy, Executive Group Chairman of RK Swamy Limited, says about the new venture, “I am happy that the next generation has taken the bold step to re-enter the business about 20 years after Hansa Vision stepped away from it. The current media landscape is quite different, and they have understood it well and are focusing on the mobile-first audience and OTT platforms. Hansa Entertainment is very different from what we do in RK Swamy Hansa Group, which is more in the space of integrated marketing services.”

FROM THE LABS.

India contributes ₹745 crore to multi-country ITER

India will “maintain its contribution” to the International Thermonuclear Experimental Reactor (ITER), a multi-country fusion reaction plant coming up in France, at ₹745 crore, according to government documents. ITER is a long-term project; according to the latest *Energy Technology Perspectives 2026* report of the International Energy Agency, the ITER, if successful, could pave the way for a 500 MW demonstration plant connected to the grid, by around 2050. India’s contribution is part of a growing global interest in fusion, even if the results are expected far in the future (see related report ‘Why nuclear fusion is gaining funding’).

Next-gen material for efficient energy storage

Newly developed polymeric materials could significantly improve energy storage and green hydrogen production, advancing access to clean energy. Scientists have created coordination polymers, Zn (DAB) and Cd (DAB), in which zinc or cadmium ions combine with organic molecules to form stable, layered structures. A key advantage is that these materials can be easily synthesised at room temperature, without complex equipment, making them suitable for largescale use. Researchers from the Centre for Nano and Soft Matter Sciences, in collaboration with Christ University, tested the materials for two critical clean-energy applications — energy storage and hydrogen generation. In laboratory tests, the materials demonstrated high energy storage capacity and retained performance even after thousands of charge-discharge cycles, indicating strong durability, according to a press release. They also performed well in more practical, device-like conditions. Equally important, the materials showed strong potential as electrocatalysts for water splitting, requiring relatively low energy input to produce hydrogen. This makes them competitive with some of the best existing materials.

Graphite from spent battery

A new technology for the reuse of spent graphite recovered from end-of-life lithium-ion batteries could convert battery waste into a high-value functional material that improves fuel cell efficiency. Researchers from the International Advanced Research Centre for Powder Metallurgy and New Materials (ARCI) recovered graphite from spent lithium-ion batteries and chemically peeled (exfoliated) it to increase surface area and the number of edge functional groups. They also carried out extensive physicochemical characterisation, electrochemical evaluation for oxygen reduction reaction and methanol tolerance, and optimisation of composition for maximum performance and stability. When integrated with platinum catalysts, the exfoliated graphite formed a conductive network that enhanced both electronic conductivity and oxygen transport while selectively adsorbing methanol molecules. This also acted as a chemical barrier, suppressing methanol oxidation and platinum CO poisoning. An optimum composition of 10 wt per cent exfoliated graphite was identified, offering superior performance and durability.

● NEXT-GEN ENERGY

Why nuclear fusion is gaining funding

RADIOACTIVE INTEREST. A host of start-ups and giants alike are betting big on atomic power from the still shaky technology

M Ramesh

Nuclear fusion, arguably a yet-to-be-proven commercial energy source — and a big-bucks game — is gaining traction. You have large research projects, such as the International Thermonuclear Experimental Reactor (ITER), a multi-country endeavour located in France (to which, incidentally, India is contributing ₹745 crore in 2026-27), alongside many fusion start-ups, which have been receiving investor interest and aim to produce energy in the next decade. According to the recently released *Energy Technology Perspectives (2026)* report of the International Energy Agency, cumulative venture capital in fusion energy companies has reached about \$11 billion. A few are from India, such as Anubal Fusion, which is technically assisted by the Tata Institute of Fundamental Research (TIFR), and Pranos Fusion, which raised ₹63 crore last month. At least three other fusion energy companies have announced fundraise in February. US-based Shine Technologies, which is into businesses such as nuclear medicine, nuclear fuel recycling and nuclear fusion, has received about \$750 million since 2018, including \$240 million in February this year. Another American company, Realta Fusion, received a loan of \$9.5 million from the Silicon Valley Bank in February, complementing the \$36 million of equity funding it secured from a host of investors, including Khosla Ventures. Realta Fusion is a startup spun out of research work at the University of Wisconsin-Madison; the company



INSIDE A TOKAMAK. The doughnut-shaped nuclear fusion reactor chamber ISTOCK

says it is “developing linear magnetic mirror machines that utilise high-temperature super-conducting magnets”. OpenStar Technologies of New Zealand got a \$21 million loan from its government to set up a “bespoke fusion energy research and development facility”. This, read in conjunction with the UK government releasing last month a fusion energy strategy paper, illustrates the keenness of governments in supporting home-grown fusion technologies — a

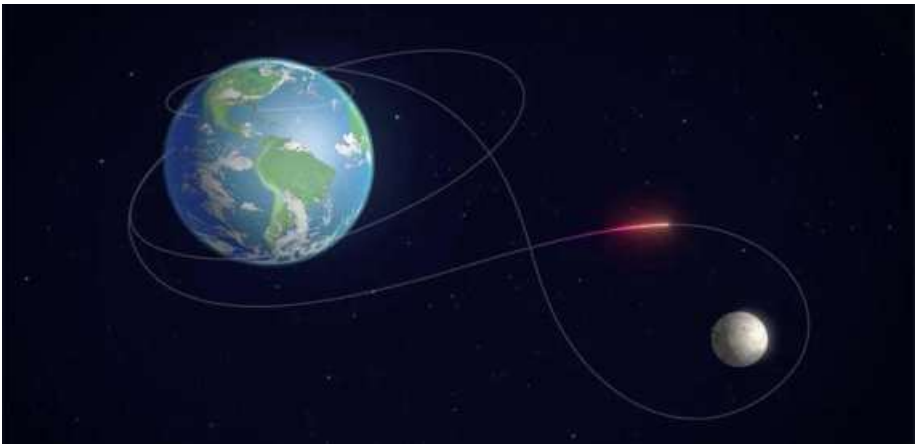
lesson for India. What explains the sudden and growing interest in fusion, which still stands on shaky ground? The IEA report reasons that “falling computation costs, more data and technical breakthroughs have driven AI capabilities to accelerate energy innovation”, while cautioning that “the extent of its real-world impact remains to be seen”. **RECENT ADVANCES** The report speaks of “some import-

ant advances in fusion technology” in recent times. Fusion energy is all about getting two atoms — mostly from the two isotopes of hydrogen, deuterium and tritium — to merge, producing heat in the process. For this, you need a pool of plasma confined in extremely high temperatures. Adding to that challenge is the problem of neutrons flying off and hitting the walls of the vessel, typically the doughnut-shaped tokamak, making the walls brittle. Tackling these problems calls for

innovative thinking — this is where start-ups, born in university research labs, see a play for themselves. For example, Germany’s Gauss Fusion, which aims to have a commercial plant in the early 2040s, is working on enhanced tritium generation using an isotope of lithium (Li-6). Tritium (unlike deuterium) is a key ingredient and in short supply. Bengaluru-based Anubal Fusion, backed by Speciale Invest, is toying with the idea of bombarding boron-11 with protons using TIFR-made high-power lasers, an approach that could sidestep some challenges encountered in conventional reactors. While nuclear fusion is dressing up for commercialisation, it is not happening anytime soon. However, as the IEA report notes, “if realised, the prize will be extraordinary”. Fusion produces a lot of cheap energy, with no emissions and shorter-lived radioactive waste, an irresistible prospect for venture capital. **‘NOT HYPE’** “The renewed investor interest in fusion isn’t hype,” says Vishesh Rajaram, Founding Partner at Speciale Invest. “It is a rational response to the scale of the climate challenge and the real progress being made in the lab,” he told *Quantum*. Speciale Invest funds deep-tech startups; its portfolio has over 40 investees. The fund house said its investment in Anubal Fusion reflected the belief that “India can, and should have a seat at the table in defining the energy technologies of the next century”. Fusion sits at the core of these technologies.

We value your feedback. Do send your comments to quantum@thehindu.co.in

● WOW. Farthest ever



LUNAR FLIGHT PATH. The Artemis-2 mission will fly a figure-eight pattern, taking the crew around the earth and then around the moon IMAGE COURTESY: NASA/JSC/GOODARD

M Ramesh

As you are reading this, three Americans (including a woman) and a Canadian are hurtling moon-ward on an epochal mission, whose success will ginger up global deep-space activities. Apollo, after whom the moon missions between 1969 and 1972 were named, was the son of Zeus, the mythical Greek king of gods, and Leto. More than half a century after the last Apollo mission, it is the turn of twin sister, Artemis, to lend her name to a moon mission. Artemis-2 is truly wow. Since the Orion capsule — the temporary residence of the four astronauts — will circle the moon without entering the moon’s orbit, the team will go farther than any human ever has — close to 4,00,000 km

from the Earth to the moon, and nearly 4,000 km beyond the far side of the moon — slightly exceeding the record set by Apollo 13. Like Apollo 8, which took humans around the moon for the first time ever, Artemis-2 will fly by the moon during its 10-day mission. Along the way, it will have to brave many demons such as van belt radiation, unexpected solar storms and galactic cosmic rays, and guard against even the tiniest of errors in navigation that could lead it astray. And its return to the earth’s atmosphere will be anything but easy — zipping in from that distance, the speed at re-entry will be far more than in a low-earth orbit mission, calling for ultra-advanced heat shields. The success of Artemis-2 will mean that humans will walk again on the moon soon.

● IN A LIMBO

Big budgets, slow science: BARC under-spends on R&D

Publicly funded nuclear research body has several important projects on hand, but is falling short on execution

M Ramesh

India’s premier nuclear research body, Bhabha Atomic Research Centre (BARC), has struggled to spend the funds allocated to it by the government for R&D. The publicly funded BARC has several projects of national importance on its table — ranging from advanced conventional reactors and fast-breeder reactors (key to harnessing India’s thorium resources) to thermal reactors for green hydrogen, isotope development and high-energy particle accelerators. These are critical for energy, nuclear medicine and even food preservation. Yet, BARC has been unable to fully utilise its R&D allocations. This pattern extends across other Department of Atomic Energy institutions under the Prime Minister’s Office, such as the Indira Gandhi Centre for Atomic Research (IGCAR), the Raja Ramanna Centre for Advanced Technology (RRCAT) and the Board of Radiation and Iso-

tope Technology (BRIT). BARC, the largest among them, was allocated ₹1,100 crore for R&D in 2025-26, while “establishment expenses” were nearly three times higher at ₹3,135 crore. The R&D allocation was later revised down to ₹919 crore. Till December 2025, BARC had spent about 55 per cent. The Budget for 2026-27 has nearly doubled BARC’s R&D allocation to ₹1,800 crore. BARC’s inability to spend allocated funds has been flagged by the Parliamentary Standing Committee examining the department’s demands for grants. The committee noted that the gap between budget estimates and actual utilisation “reflects a recurring pattern of over-estimation... compounded by procedural delays in project execution”. Among the major projects pending for decades, the accelerator-driven subcritical systems (ADSS) project has been on the anvil since at least 2001. Similarly, plans for a high-intensity 1 GeV proton accelerator, potentially placing India at the forefront of nuclear fusion technology, have seen little progress for over two decades. BARC’s high-temperature reactor for hydrogen production was presented internationally as early as 2006, but no product is yet in the market. The committee cautioned that higher allocations must be matched by “improvements in execution readiness”. BRIT, a unit of BARC, allocated ₹88 crore in 2025-26 (later revised to ₹35 crore), spent only ₹12.43 crore, a third of the revised estimate. The 2026-27 Budget has again raised the allocation to ₹76 crore.



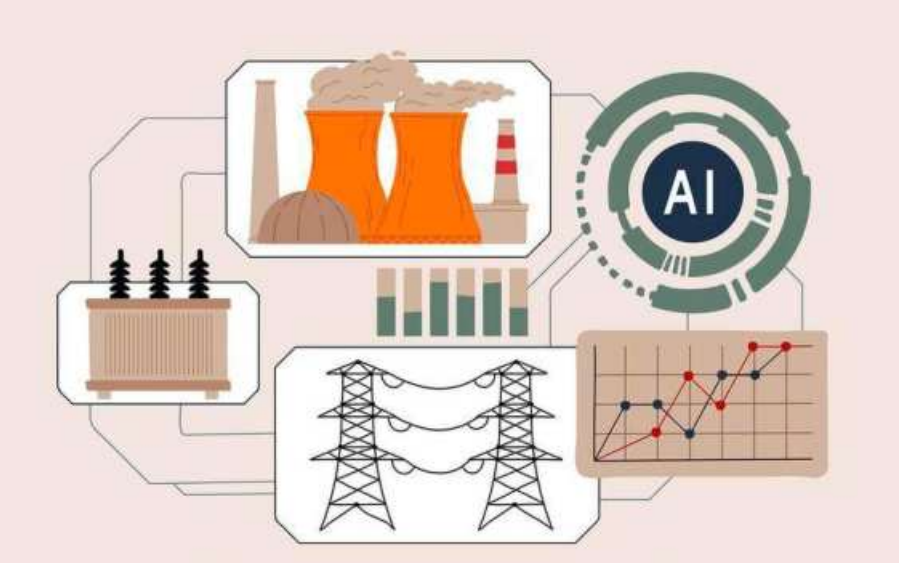
ISTOCK

lear fusion technology, have seen little progress for over two decades. BARC’s high-temperature reactor for hydrogen production was presented internationally as early as 2006, but no product is yet in the market. The committee cautioned that higher allocations must be matched by “improvements in execution readiness”. BRIT, a unit of BARC, allocated ₹88 crore in 2025-26 (later revised to ₹35 crore), spent only ₹12.43 crore, a third of the revised estimate. The 2026-27 Budget has again raised the allocation to ₹76 crore.

RRCAT spent ₹42 crore (till December 2025) against an original allocation of ₹178 crore and a revised estimate of ₹63 crore. The gap is even starker for IGCAR, where the original allocation of ₹225 crore was cut to ₹68 crore, with actual spending at ₹50 crore. **‘EXPENDITURE VACUUM’** The department attributed the underspending to project cycles — several projects were concluded in 2023-24, while new ones began only in October 2025. The committee, however, was not convinced, calling it “indicative of a deeper structural issue”. It observed that the gap between the conclusion of one project cycle and the initiation of the next cycle “has resulted in a prolonged expenditure vacuum at a premier nuclear research institution”. Data from the report also show that establishment costs of the four research units — BARC, IGCAR, RRCAT and BRIT — are more than double their R&D spending: ₹5,171 crore versus ₹2,396 crore in 2025-26 (revised estimates).

● PEAK LEARNING

Power supply lessons for AI



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N Nagaraj

India’s electricity grid has long resisted the forecasting methods that work elsewhere. A recent study, ‘Indian peak power demand forecasting: Transformer-based implementation of temporal architecture’, by Vishvadiya Luhach and Shashwat Jha, applied a transformer-based architecture to Indian peak power demand and achieved a mean absolute percentage error of 4.15 per cent across a six-year daily dataset. The number matters less than what the attempt reveals about the problem. The structural difficulty of India’s demand curve has several layers. Agricultural irrigation draws heavily on subsidised, largely unmetered power that follows crop cycles and monsoon patterns across States with different cropping calendars, groundwater conditions and seasonal rainfall. Historical consumption data carries all of this embedded complexity without labelling it. The pre-monsoon months compound this. From April through June, cooling demand peaks as temperatures climb toward their annual high, while reservoirs depleted through the dry season constrain hydro-generation capacity. Supply tightens precisely when demand is most acute. A temperature variable captures one side of this; it cannot capture the reservoir cycle, which moves adversely against it at the same time. Most fundamentally, In-

dia’s observed peak demand strains supply and is hence expensive. Large portions of the population remain underserved or unconnected, and the training signal understates latent consumption by an uncertain margin, which will shift as electrification expands. Mature grids in western Europe have stable, metered and climatically moderate demand profiles. India’s grid has none of these properties. The temporal fusion transformer handles this environment better than its competitors for a specific architectural reason: It processes three input types simultaneously — historical observations, known future variables such as calendar dates and public holidays, and static metadata — without requiring the analyst to pre-specify how they interact. It learns the weighting. Its variable selection mechanism highlights which inputs drove a given forecast, making its reasoning available for inspection. For regulators, a model that can be audited is qualitatively different from one that produces only a number.

DOMAIN FIT The study’s most telling result involves a model that did not perform well. The temporal convolutional network, a sophisticated deep-learning architecture with a creditable record in sequence modelling, was outperformed by naive seasonal forecasting: A method that essentially extends yesterday’s pattern with a drift adjustment. The paper is lim-

ited enough that a more rigorous investigation — with regional disaggregation, more model comparisons and finer-grained data — might tell a different story about the TCN. The result still points to something real. General purpose architectures designed to handle heterogeneous, multi-layered inputs fared better on India’s demand curve than a deeper model optimised for sequential pattern extraction. Domain fit outweighed architectural sophistication, and India’s grid exposed the difference. A more accurate forecast only improves outcomes if the institution receiving it can act on it. Decisions about generation capacity, transmission investment and storage procurement require forecasts that look years ahead; infrastructure takes years to build and decades to pay off. Acting on those forecasts requires procurement flexibility, regulatory frameworks and pricing signals, which most State electricity boards and central planners do not yet have. The transformer’s migration from language parsing to power grid management reflects something specific: A compact set of mathematical operations, designed to identify which parts of a sequence matter most for predicting what comes next, generalises across domains defined by long-range temporal dependencies. India’s grid, with its accumulated complexity, is among the most demanding tests of that generalisation. Passing it is a result worth examining.

GLOBAL BYTES.

Maersk retrofits 200 ships to cut costs

In a largescale programme involving 50 shipowners, Danish shipping major AP Moller-Maersk is, in close collaboration with the owners, retrofitting around 200 vessels in its time-chartered fleet. The main aim of the programme is to reduce the slot cost by improving fuel efficiency and cargo-carrying capacity, which would also help reduce greenhouse gas emissions. In all, Maersk and its time-charter partners have executed more than 1,500 projects across 200 vessels, and an additional 1,000 projects are scheduled to be finalised by 2027. The investment cost for these solutions is split between Maersk and the vessel owners, the company said.

Air cargo demand up 11.2% in February

Global air cargo demand, measured in cargo tonne-km (CTK), rose by 11.2 per cent in 2026 compared to February 2025 (+11.6 per cent for international operations). Capacity, measured in available cargo tonne-km (ACTK), increased by 8.5 per cent (+9.8 per cent for international operations), according to the International Air Transport Association (ATA). “Even considering the boost February received from the movement of goods ahead of the Lunar New Year, the month showed strong growth,” said Willie Walsh, IATA’s Director General. The war in West Asia, however, makes it difficult to forecast the full-year performance, he added.

Did you know?

Railway norms to use the middle berth

Essential berth etiquette



TTE mediation: If a dispute arises over timing, the TTE has the authority to enforce official rules.

Safety add-on: Ensure the middle berth is properly secured when in use and properly folded when not in use

Be flexible: Consider allowing extra rest for the elderly, pregnant, or those with medical conditions



Daytime: 6 am to 10 pm. The berth must be folded down to provide seating for everyone

Daytime relaxation on middle berth (Incorrect usage)

Cramped sitting space versus seating rights

Be considerate for a smooth and respectful journey

Source: Southern Railway

RE POSTS.

- Kandla Creates History!**

Setting a new benchmark in renewable energy logistics, DPA Kandla achieves the highest cargo volume (CBM) handled in Wind Turbine Blades - a massive 1,67,675 CBM in a single shipment carrying 153 blades!

A landmark moment with the arrival of MV KANG QI FU HUA, reinforcing Kandla's leadership in handling critical green energy project cargo.

Key Contributors:

CHA – Ace Global Logistics

Stevedores – Samundra Marine

Vessel Agent – J M Baxi

Deendayal Port Authority, Kandla

@Deendayal_Port
- Under the leadership of Hon'ble Civil Aviation Minister Shri Ram Mohan Naidu, passenger-centric initiatives are gaining momentum. Affordable and pocket-friendly food outlet-UDAN Yatri Café is expanding rapidly and now operational at 24 airports. A step towards making air travel more comfortable, convenient, and accessible for all.**

MoCA_GoI

@MoCA_GoI
- Tug MV Trishul, along with barges Ajay and Dikhu, has successfully transported 1500 tonnes of cargo from Haldia to Pandu Port in Guwahati, Assam. The consignment included 1200 tonnes of @TataSteelLtd slag cement and 300 tonnes of @SAILsteel TMT bars.**

IWAI

@IWAI_ShipMin

Truck rental rates

Rentals for 18-tonne payload

Truck route	Rentals as on		% change
	Feb 19	Mar 19	
Delhi-Mumbai-Delhi	1,69,000	1,70,000	0.59
Delhi-Nagpur-Delhi	1,57,000	1,58,000	0.63
Delhi-Kolkata-Delhi	1,69,000	1,70,000	0.59
Delhi-Guwahati-Delhi	1,93,000	1,92,000	-0.52
Delhi-Hyderabad-Delhi	1,99,000	1,98,000	-0.51
Delhi-Chennai-Delhi	2,16,000	2,15,000	-0.47
Delhi-Bengaluru-Delhi	2,20,000	2,23,000	1.35
Delhi-Ranchi-Delhi	1,65,000	1,66,000	0.60
Delhi-Raipur-Delhi	1,63,000	1,64,000	0.61
Delhi-Kandla-Delhi	1,38,000	1,40,000	1.43
Mumbai-Chennai-Mumbai	1,68,000	1,69,000	0.59
Ludhiana-Hyderabad-Ludhiana	2,00,000	2,00,000	0.00
Mumbai-Kolkata-Mumbai	1,99,000	2,00,000	0.50
Chennai-Ahmedabad-Chennai	2,10,000	2,12,000	0.94
Bengaluru-Kolkata-Bengaluru	2,10,000	2,11,000	0.47
Bengaluru-Mumbai-Bengaluru	1,40,000	1,39,000	-0.72
Delhi-Thiruvananthapuram-Delhi	2,80,000	2,81,000	0.36
Guwahati-Mumbai-Guwahati	2,80,000	2,81,000	0.36
Nagpur-Chennai-Nagpur	1,62,000	1,63,000	0.61
Kolkata-Guwahati-Kolkata	1,52,000	1,51,000	-0.66
Indore-Delhi-Indore	1,45,000	1,46,000	0.68
Ahmedabad-Indore-Ahmedabad	97,000	96,000	-1.04
Vijayawada-Mumbai-Vijayawada	1,59,000	1,58,000	-0.63
Vijayawada-Kolkata-Vijayawada	1,52,000	1,51,000	-0.66
Mumbai-Nagpur-Mumbai	1,10,000	1,12,000	1.79
Mumbai-Pune-Mumbai	61,000	62,000	1.61
Mumbai-Aurangabad-Mumbai	80,000	82,000	2.44
Mumbai-Nashik-Mumbai	60,000	61,000	1.64

Figures in ₹

Source: Subham Freight Carriers India Pvt Ltd

COHESIVE GROWTH

‘Integration is vital for Indian ports’

SAFE HARBOURS. IAPH chief Jens Meier urges prioritising multimodal connectivity and digitisation of the maritime sector

T E Raja Simhan

CV Jens Meier has been the CEO of Germany’s Hamburg Port Authority since 2008. With over 25 years of experience in the port, logistics, finance and IT sectors, the computer science graduate is a recognised leader in the maritime industry. In 2023, Meier was elected President of the International Association of Ports and Harbours (IAPH) and re-elected for a second term in October 2025. Tokyo-based IAPH, a non-governmental organisation, represents over 200 ports and 170 maritime-related businesses across 90 countries. It acts as a global alliance for port authorities and operators, focusing on decarbonisation, digitalisation and risk management. During his recent visit to Chennai, Meier spoke on issues related to Indian ports.

Edited excerpts:

You’ve been travelling to many ports globally. What is your assessment of the scenario in India? Over the last decade, India has made remarkable progress. Large infrastructure projects have been completed, and connectivity, especially road connectivity in Mumbai, has improved significantly. Infrastructure is the backbone of logistics, and it’s clear India has focused strongly on that. However, the next phase must be about integration — stronger rail networks, multimodal connectivity, digital systems and hinterland efficiency.

How do Indian ports compare with global peers like the Port of Hamburg? Hamburg is a mature port embedded in a highly standardised European logistics system. Ports like Jawaharlal Nehru Port and Chennai have scale and ambition, and they are improving rapidly. But there is still room for improvement, especially in rail modal share, process standardisation, and digital integration. India has the potential. Now it is about execution and prioritisation.

India has a unique mix of government-run ports and private operators. How do you see this?



SYNCHRONISING STRENGTHS. CV Jens Meier, CEO of the Hamburg Port Authority and President of the International Association of Ports and Harbours

I don’t see this as a weakness at all. In fact, it can be a strength. Globally, many ports operate under landlord models, where private operators run terminals while public authorities manage infrastructure. Take Mundra port in Gujarat, for example. It demonstrates how private-led development can be highly efficient. But, at the end of the day, success depends on the entire maritime logistics ecosystem — hinterland connectivity, dry ports, rail corridors and government alignment. Ownership structure matters less than ecosystem performance.

Where do you see the biggest gaps? Rail connectivity is one area that needs a lot of improvement. In Germany, rail becomes competitive beyond 150 km. In India, I understand it is viable only beyond 500 km. Increasing rail share would improve resilience and sustainability. Second is prioritisation. Indian ports often have many ambitious ideas at once. Leading global ports typically focus on three strategic priorities, execute them

within 12–24 months, and then move to the next set. Third, digital standards — even small differences such as how ports define ‘estimated time of arrival’ can create inefficiencies. Harmonisation is key.

You also visited cruise terminals. How do you view that segment? I was impressed by the new cruise infrastructure in India, compared to what existed earlier. But cruise success is not only about building a terminal.

It requires an ecosystem — route planning, market positioning, business development and service standards. India has a growing middle class and a young population, which makes this an interesting market. But the product must be clearly defined — luxury, mass market or hybrid — and aligned with customer expectations.

What are green and digital corridors? What do they mean in practical terms? It means cooperation between ports on

alternative fuels, shore power systems, standardised safety protocols and digital data exchange. With Ennarasu Karunesan as our IAPH Regional Director, over the past four years, Indian ports have been actively engaging with the IAPH, marking a significant step towards global integration. If Hamburg and Indian ports collaborate on a green and digital corridor, it would involve standardised bunkering procedures, compatible IT systems and shared safety training standards.

How important is workforce development in this transformation? Extremely important. Digital transformation is not about replacing people — it’s about empowering them. If we move toward LNG, hydrogen or ammonia-fuelled vessels, port workers and seafarers must be trained under global standards. Safety, emergency protocols and operational handling must be aligned internationally.

How have the geopolitical disruptions affected ports globally? Ports are adaptable by nature. Storms, canal blockages and geopolitical tensions have always existed. The real challenge is uncertainty. Investors hesitate when trade routes are unpredictable. Strong, resilient ports provide stability in such times. In fact, global trade supports global peace — and ports are the enablers of global trade.

With the progress in the India-EU trade agreement, what opportunities do you see for ports? The expectation is that exports between Europe and India will increase significantly. That is a major opportunity for ports. However, balanced trade is crucial. Empty containers are inefficient. Sustainable trade corridors require cargo flows in both directions. If managed well, this agreement can strengthen long-term maritime cooperation.

How long before an Indian port joins the ‘big league’? India certainly has the potential. The key factors will be focus, KPI-driven management, transparency and international standard alignment... if there is a strong “alliance of willingness”.

AI WAVES ROLL IN

Future-ready ‘thinking ports’



ISTOCK

TK Ramachandran
TR Shreyas

Waves are not new to ports! So what is one more, even if it is an AI wave? Ports are important links in complex logistics chains. The major ports in India have, over the last few years, transformed into smart ports, with IT and automation bringing about major gains in efficiencies. However, with the AI wave, the smart ports will have to become intelligent. The digital initiatives include enterprise-wide business systems, the National Logistics Portal (Marine), Maritime Single Window module, Sagar Setu platform, and e-Samudra (unified maritime services portal). Processes earlier handled physically are now performed digitally. The ‘One Nation, One Document’ and ‘One Nation, One Process’ (ONOD and ONOP) exercises launched last year showed that each port ecosystem (customs, immigration, health and so on) demanded its own set of documents and processes, many redundant. The exercises arrived at a core set of standardised documents and processes across ports, yielding efficiency gains.

WHY AI IN PORTS AI can add value to the existing digital initiatives. It can further increase efficiency and ease of doing business, while lowering costs with gains in productivity. AI can enhance project planning, provide decision support in operations, facilitate trade, ease compliance with safety and environmental norms, and rationalise energy usage. A pilot project by

IIT-Madras for VO Chidambaranar Port in Thoothukudi to determine how AI can help in congestion forecasting and just-in-time berthing showed many potential gains, including savings on fuel and time. AI requires enormous amounts of data to learn. Existing deployments are project-driven, terminal- or port-based and vendor-led, with the data being fragmented, the intelligence siloed and limited reuse of data across ports. So, even if an AI layer is built on top of this existing ecosystem, there is another ‘to-do’ list — AI needs to be institutionalised and treated as ‘digital public infrastructure’ (DPI). This approach will lead to standardised data more interoperability and shared registries, services, identities, workflows and analytics, as well as ensure cybersecurity. Without this, each port will keep inventing AI solutions individually, intelligence will remain locked inside vendor platforms, and there can be no cross-learning across ports. With DPI, models can be reused and improved with system-wide gains.

CHALLENGES AHEAD When it comes to the challenges in implementing AI at ports, firstly the existing fragmented data systems imply that AI cannot see the full system. Common port standards and registries can help resolve this issue. Vendor lock-in with proprietary models can be avoided with open AI and modular services. Weak decision-integration will mean dashboards without impact, which can be corrected by embedding AI into SOPs and workflows. Lack of institutional capacity will lead to either blind trust or under-

use of AI, both of which are dangerous; mitigation can be through shared analytic platforms and training. Accountability concerns can be addressed through models where humans have the final say and clear SOPs. A shared national framework in which port data standards and AI governance norms are well defined will help in deploying solutions across ports.

INTELLIGENT VS SMART A thinking port will be decision-led, unlike a smart port, which is technology-led. The focus will be on judgment and trade-offs rather than mere automation, and predictive and anticipatory insights rather than simple real-time visibility. It will optimise across systems, rather than within silos, and plan for outcomes rather than just reacting to events. Smart ports simply look at what is happening right now; thinking ports will look at what is likely to happen, what should be done and whether it may be the right choice. Ultimately, AI should help the industry as well as governance. The next phase of port reform would be not about adding more technology but embedding intelligence into how ports govern themselves. While smart ports can operate faster, thinking ports will be (hopefully) wiser and future-ready.

Ramachandran was till recently Secretary, Ministry of Ports, Shipping, and Waterways; Shreyas is a public policy and IT consultant. Views are personal

We value your feedback. Do send your comments to bl.logistics@thehindu.co.in

GATEWAY TO GROWTH

Vizag port’s trade multiplier effect



DEXTERITY. Visakhapatnam port handles cargo ranging from petroleum and coal to iron ore and steel

G Naga Sridhar

For Visakhapatnam, the sea has always been an economic lifeline — a catalyst for the development of this coastal city in Andhra Pradesh. From steel and petroleum to minerals and coal, the port has long defined the rhythm of local businesses. The latest cargo numbers from Visakhapatnam Port Authority (VPA) suggest this maritime engine of growth is gathering momentum. In 2025–26, exports handled by the port rose 19.4 per cent to 33.67 million tonnes year-on-year, while imports grew 5.5 per cent to 57.45 million tonnes, underlining the city’s prominence in India’s trade and logistics map. For businesses in and around Visakhapatnam, the surge signals stronger industrial activity, improved cargo movement and renewed demand across sectors. “The growth momentum was broad-based across bulk, break-bulk and liquid cargo segments, underlining the port’s capability to efficiently handle diverse cargo profiles and cater to evolving trade requirements,” M Angamuthu, Chairperson, VPA, told *businessline*. The story behind the numbers is one of diversification. Crude oil emerged as one of the biggest drivers of cargo growth, posting a 15 per cent increase to signal the region’s continuing importance in petroleum and energy logistics. Iron ore and pellets cargo recorded 13.9 per cent growth, pointing to sustained demand from metal and manufacturing sectors, while thermal coal volumes doubled. Other commodities, such as alumina and anthracite coal, also posted notable gains, indicating the widening industrial base that the port now serves. For Vizag, this growth feeds directly into the local economy. Higher cargo throughput means increased activity for shipping agents, transport operators, warehousing companies, customs intermediaries and thousands of port-linked workers. It also mirrors the city’s larger economic aspirations. With its strategic location on the East Coast, strong rail-road connectivity and proximity to industrial corridors, Visakhapatnam is increasingly positioning itself as a gateway for eastern and central India’s trade flows. “By enhancing efficiency and expanding our cargo basket, Visakhapatnam Port Authority is well positioned to support India’s growing maritime and economic ambitions, and play a pivotal role in driving regional and national economic growth,” Angamuthu said. As Vizag pushes for greater investments in industry, logistics and maritime infrastructure, the port remains at the heart of its growth story — every rise in tonnage often translates into broader business confidence onshore.

Dubai curbs on Indian carriers under scrutiny as Gulf conflict hits operations

BURNING FUEL. The issue was recently communicated to the government by the FIA, seeking review

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

The disparity in air traffic access between India and Dubai is coming under scrutiny at a time when airlines on both sides are operating under exceptional conditions due to the ongoing Gulf conflict, sources told *businessline*.

Accordingly, the issue was recently flagged by the Federation of Indian Airlines (FIA) in a communication to the Ministry of Civil Aviation (MoCA), seeking review of capacity deployment in the current environment.

In the communication, FIA told MoCA that Dubai International Airport (DXB) authorities had mandated flight cancellations for the Northern Summer 2026 season between April 20 and May 31, restricting foreign



DENIED SPACE. Indian carriers flying to Europe and the United States are being forced to take longer routes, resulting in higher fuel burn and extended flight durations REUTERS

carriers to only one rotation per day.

DIFFERENT RULES

However, UAE-based carriers, such as Emirates and FlyDubai, have resumed operations to India at pre-disruption levels and are not subject to similar restrictions, resulting in what industry stakeholders described as an uneven playing field.

Separately, industry sources told *businessline* that Emirates and FlyDubai together operate around 35 daily flights between Dubai and multiple Indian cities, while Indian carriers continue to have limited ability to scale up services on these routes, despite sustained demand on the corridor.

In its communication, the FIA noted that the continuation of such restrictions is

already leading to anti-competitive market conditions, operational inefficiencies, substantial revenue losses and passenger inconvenience.

EXTENDED FLIGHTS

Speaking to *businessline*, industry stakeholders said with portions of airspace restricted, Indian carriers flying to Europe and the US are being forced to take longer routes, resulting in higher fuel burn and extended flight durations, in almost all cases adding hours to flight time. These operational challenges, coupled with higher fuel consumption, are further straining airline economics at a time when cost pressures remain elevated, sources added.

“The imbalance becomes more visible in situations like this. Indian carriers are dealing with longer routes

and higher operating costs, while also having limited room to expand capacity where demand exists,” an airline executive said.

According to industry stakeholders, the current situation reflects how capacity and access are being managed during a period of disruption, with airlines seeking a more balanced approach under existing bilateral arrangements.

Consequently, the industry body urged the government to engage with Dubai to remove the restrictions and allow Indian carriers to restore operations to pre-disruption levels.

It suggested that reciprocal measures could be considered, including restricting the operations of Dubai carriers in line with the cumulative seat capacity deployed by Indian airlines on the route.

Ad volumes jump by 10% in IPL 2026, Google tops charts: Report

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

The IPL’s 19th season has recorded higher ad volumes compared to the previous season.

According to the latest TAM Sports data, TV ad volumes were up 10 per cent in the first four matches of the ongoing IPL season compared to the first four matches of the previous season.

This is despite the ongoing geopolitical uncertainties, during which companies across sectors are witnessing higher raw material costs pressures.

At the same time, the number of advertisers were lower by 26 per cent in the first four matches of the IPL’s 19th season at 43 compared to 58 advertisers during a similar number of matches in the previous season.

“While IPL’s 19th season



recorded higher ad volumes than IPL 18 (first four matches), it featured a 15 per cent narrower category mix and 26 per cent fewer advertisers, pointing towards a more concentrated and high-intensity advertising landscape,” the report by TAM Sports, a division of TAM Media, noted.

MORE CONCENTRATED

E-commerce (other services) led the chart in terms of category-wise contribution, with over 14 per cent share to ad volumes on TV,

followed closely by mouth fresheners. Air-conditioners, financial corporate institutions and paints were among the top five categories in terms of contribution to ad volumes. “Collectively, these top five categories accounted for 44 per cent share of the ad volumes in the first four matches of the IPL’s 19th season,” the report noted.

Google emerged as the top advertiser, contributing nearly 13 per cent to the ad volume share in these four matches. Reliance Consumer Products, Havells India, Vishnu Packaging (Vimal Elaichi) and KP Pan Foods were among the top five advertisers in terms of share of ad volumes on TV. “The top five advertisers contributed 36 per cent of the overall ad volumes during these four matches,” the report added.

Additionally, nine new categories and 45 new brands were seen advertising on TV during these matches.

Danfoss India’s electric kitchen serves as a blueprint for industry

After investing around ₹1.7 crore, the company is reaping multiple benefits and attracting others who want to see and learn

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

As the government nudges institutional canteens to go electric, a factory in Oragadam, near Chennai, which has been running a fully electric kitchen set up for two years now, is inspiring confidence among Tamil Nadu’s businesses to take the path.

Even as *chapatis* and *dosas* disappear from industrial canteens due to fuel rationing, it is business as usual at the cafeteria of Danfoss India, a Danish multinational engineering major, that has a large presence in the Oragadam industrial

corridor. From *dosas*, omelettes and *chapatis* to *papads* and other deep fried delicacies, the canteen has been serving its employees its regular menu three times a day.

LESS EMISSIONS

Two-and-a-half years ago, as Danfoss was looking to expand its conventional kitchen and mapping carbon emissions, it realised that roughly 400 sq m additional kitchen space was needed, along with more gas.

That is when the company decided to evaluate the electric kitchen option and found that it had multiple benefits.



CHOOSING WISELY. The electric kitchen at the Danfoss facility at Oragadam, near Chennai BUJOY GHOSH

businessline took a walk through the electric kitchen of Danfoss, which includes a

deep frying pan, a cooking range, a tilting brazing pan, and a tawa for hot *dosas*,

chapatis and omelettes, among others.

Consuming up to 290 KW of electricity in total, the entire system is supported by renewable energy.

ECONOMIC GAINS

Ravichandran Purushothaman, President of Danfoss India, said that the kitchen involved an up-front investment of around ₹1.7 crore and a fairly simple training regime for the staff, but the payback period had been less than 3 years for them.

It’s not just to beat the geopolitical risks or to go green, but there’s a logical business case, he added.

Danfoss estimates annual operational cost savings by going electric at about ₹35 lakh. Not just that, it removed 27 tonnes of LPG annually from operations, and reduced 87 tonnes per year in carbon emissions. The electric range cooks 40 per cent faster, saving over 12,600+ work hours per year, company estimates show.

During the peak cooking hours, working with the set of electric appliances, the company is able to serve around 2,000 meals a day.

“If you move to electric and if you have integrated solar power (like Danfoss does), it pays you back even faster. Second, it is also giv-

ing you a 30 per cent benefit on the real estate space because you don’t need space to keep cylinders,” Purushothaman said.

The government should look at offering some amount of subsidy for industries setting up electric kitchens, he added.

CURIOUS VISITORS

Interestingly, as fuel shortage hits corporate canteens, Danfoss’ kitchen is busy welcoming visitors. “In the last two weeks, we have had about 14 companies visit to check out our electric kitchen and our supplier too is overloaded (with queries),” said Purushothaman.

IT workers’ body seeks govt policy amid mass layoffs

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

IT employees’ body Nascent Information Technology Employees Senate (NITES) has exhorted tech firms to prioritise reskilling over layoffs, while calling for policy intervention to bring stronger safeguards and mandatory severance norms to protect white-collar workers as aggressive AI build-outs by industry trigger job cuts and uncertainty for the workforce.

NITES argued that although tech profits remain strong, weakening job security raises serious questions about corporate responsibility and accountability.

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